

The Byzantine senate elected a young noble, Nicolas Kanabos, as emperor, and he refused to back the crusaders. Denied their promised payments, the crusaders and their allies, the Venetians, responded with a ruthless attack on the city. They raped and killed civilians, looted churches, and demolished priceless works of art. Constantinople was all but destroyed.

Rise of the Ottomans

Before capturing Constantinople, the Ottoman Empire had already expanded from Anatolia into the Balkans. Afterward, in the 16th century, it expanded into the eastern Mediterranean, along the banks of the Red Sea, and into North Africa. The defeat of the Mamluks in Egypt in 1517, and wars against the Safavids, one of Persia's most significant ruling dynasties, gave the Ottomans control of a whole swathe of the Arab Middle East.

The Ottoman Empire was a Muslim State and the sultans saw it as their duty to promote the spread of Islam. Nevertheless it tolerated Christians and Jews in a subsidiary status and made extensive use of enslaved people. Many languages were

spoken and faiths followed within its domains, but it dealt with the conflicting religious and political differences by setting up vassal (subordinate) states in some regions. Territories such as Transylvania and Crimea paid tribute (made regular payments) to the emperor, but they were not ruled by him directly, and acted as buffer zones between Muslim and Christian areas. Some vassal states, including Bulgaria, Serbia, and Bosnia, were eventually absorbed into the larger empire; others retained their vassal status.

Government and military

The Ottomans evolved a strong system of government that combined local administration with central control. The sultan—whose brothers were customarily murdered at his accession—was supreme ruler. He had a council of advisers, later a deputy, who ruled on his behalf. Local areas were ruled by military governors (beys) under the emperor's overall control, but local councils kept the beys' authority in check.

Non-Muslim communities within the empire were allowed a degree of self-rule through a system of separate courts called millets. The millets allowed Armenian, Jewish, and Orthodox Christian communities to rule according to their own laws in cases that did not involve Muslims. This balanced combination of central and »

When lighted tapers were put to the “innumerable machines” ranged along a four-mile section of the city walls, the world's first concerted artillery barrage exploded into life.

